

LOCALS ARE ALLOWED
TO CUT TEAK TREES AND
SELL THE WOOD



Out of the Red SHADOW

From impoverished zone and Maoist magnet to icon of development, Dang has taken a great leap forward

| By Uday Mahurkar |

In a small, hilly district of south Gujarat lies the story of a people moving out of the shadow of war and death, guns and bullets to embrace peace and prosperity. It is the story of bravery in the face of death, of battling armed Maoists who are slicing through India's tribal heartland, challenging the writ of the state. Apart from guns, the Maoist's primary weapon has been the exploitation of poverty and poor governance to establish their diktat. In the face of such opposition, Dang, a Gujarat district, has emerged as a model for

beating back Maoism through responsive administration and imaginative public schemes. With the support of the administration, the local administration has countered Naxalism by effectively taking to the impoverished people the fruits of development and keeping them engaged in a steady dialogue with the Government, thus appealing to their sensitivity and teaching them the

ways of progress.

Says Baiju Mali, 54, sarpanch of Kosimda village where Naxalites had penetrated deep in the 1990s, "Our village, which was once very poor and ill-equipped, has changed in the past decade with development reaching deep amongst the people." Pointing to the growth of the Naxalite movement in Dang, Somabhai Tunda, 43, sarpanch of nearby Bhenskatri village, adds, "Outsiders turned locals against the state, capitalising on their poverty and instigating them to grab forest land. But good governance has turned the situation around. Tribal welfare schemes are not just on paper here and the administration is much more responsive."

Kosimda, one of the biggest villages in Dang with a population of 3,000, epitomises the makeover story. In the mid-'90s, a tribal woman was shot dead by forest guards when

"The atmosphere of hope prevents locals from falling into the trap of the Maoists."

S.K. NANDA, IAS OFFICER IN CHARGE OF DANG